

Locking Down a Self-Checkout Kiosk

A step-by-step guide for setting up a self-checkout terminal so customers can only ever use the checkout screen — never the browser, the desktop, or the internet. No technical background required; just follow the parts in order.

The idea, in plain terms

A self-checkout terminal is just a browser window showing the checkout page. Left alone, any browser lets a person do things a store never wants a customer doing on that screen — open a new tab, browse the internet, or poke around the desktop. Fixing that takes **two separate things working together**, and it's worth understanding both before you start:

A **A PIN, set per terminal.** Staff choose a short PIN for each self-checkout register. On the kiosk itself, a hidden key combo brings up a number pad — get the PIN right, and the screen locks into fullscreen or unlocks out of it. Get it wrong, or don't know it, and nothing happens.

B **Kiosk mode on the PC itself.** This is a setting on the terminal's computer, not in the app. It tells the browser to launch with no address bar, no tabs, and no way to back out of it — the checkout page is the only thing the screen can ever show.

THE ONE THING TO REMEMBER

Part **A** on its own is a speed bump, not a lock — every browser lets a person press `Esc` or `F11` to see the address bar again, and no PIN can be wired onto that, in any browser, on any website. Part **B** is what actually removes the address bar so there's nothing to escape to. **Do both** — Part A for day-to-day staff use, Part B for the guarantee.

PART A

Set the Lockdown PIN

Do this once per terminal, from the main office computer (not the kiosk itself).

- 1 Open the main POS app and go to the **Terminals** page.
- 2 Find the self-checkout terminal in the list, and click the small **key icon** on its row (tooltip: "Self-checkout kiosk pairing").
- 3 In the panel that opens, scroll to **Fullscreen Lockdown PIN**. Type a PIN of 4 to 6 digits and click **Set PIN**.
- 4 Write this PIN down somewhere staff can find it — there's no way to look it up again afterwards. If it's ever forgotten, come back here and set a new one; the old one simply stops working.

WHO CAN DO THIS

Only **Tenant Administrator** and **Branch Manager** accounts can see or use this panel. Cashiers and other roles can't set or change it.

PART A

Using It Day to Day

On the kiosk screen itself, there is **no button** for this — on purpose, so a browsing customer never sees anything inviting them to tap it.

- 1 Anywhere on the checkout screen, press **Ctrl** + **Shift** + **L**.
- 2 A number pad appears, sized to exactly however many digits the PIN is — a 4-digit PIN shows 4 dots, not 6.
- 3 Type the PIN and tap **Enter**. The screen locks into fullscreen if it wasn't already, or drops back out if it was — same combo, same PIN, both directions.

PART B Turning On Real Kiosk Mode

This is the part that actually matters. It's done once, on the terminal's own PC, by whoever sets up that computer — not something staff repeat day to day.

Instead of opening the checkout page in a normal browser window, launch it with a special command that tells the browser: *show only this page, forever, with no address bar and no way out*. Open the Windows **Run** box (**Win** + **R**) or a shortcut icon, and use one of these:

Google Chrome

```
chrome.exe --kiosk --new-window --user-data-dir="C:\KioskProfile" "http://your-terminal-address"
```

Microsoft Edge

```
msedge.exe --kiosk "http://your-terminal-address" --edge-kiosk-type=fullscreen --user-data-dir="(
```

DON'T SKIP --USER-DATA-DIR

If that browser is already open on the PC, this command just adds a normal tab to it and silently ignores kiosk mode — you'll see "Opening in existing browser session" and nothing will look different. The `--user-data-dir` part forces a brand-new, separate browser window that actually honors kiosk mode. Make sure that browser is fully closed first, or always use this flag.

Make it launch automatically

Save the command above as a shortcut, and place that shortcut in the Windows Startup folder (**Win** + **R** , type `shell:startup`) so the terminal boots straight into the checkout screen with no one needing to open anything by hand.

PART B+

Locking Down Windows Itself (optional, more thorough)

Kiosk mode locks the browser; it doesn't touch Windows underneath it. A customer who knows to press **Alt** + **F4** could still close the browser and reach the desktop. Closing that gap is a Windows setting, done by whoever manages the store's PCs:

- 1 Create a separate Windows account for the kiosk with no admin rights, and set it to sign in automatically and launch the kiosk browser command above.
- 2 Turn on **Windows Assigned Access** (Settings → Accounts → Other users → Set up a kiosk) for that account, locked to the kiosk browser. This removes the Start menu, taskbar, and every other app for that account.
- 3 If needed, disable Task Manager and Alt+Tab for that account via Local Group Policy ([gpedit.msc](#)).
- 4 **Staff access for maintenance:** use Ctrl+Shift+L + the PIN to drop out of fullscreen first, then use the Assigned Access exit gesture (or simply restart into the admin account) to reach Windows.

Common Questions

I pressed Esc and saw the address bar — is that a bug?

No. That's every browser's built-in escape hatch, and it's **always there** until Part B (kiosk mode) is switched on for that PC. Once Part B is on, Esc has nothing to reveal — there's no address bar rendered at all.

Can we make the address bar itself need a PIN?

No — the address bar belongs to the browser, not to any website, so a website can never see what's typed into it or block it. The only fix is removing the address bar entirely, which is exactly what Part B does.

Does the PIN ever get sent anywhere unsafe?

No. The store's server only ever answers "yes, that matches" or "no, it doesn't" — the PIN itself is stored as a one-way scrambled value, the same way a login password is, and is never shown again after it's set.

What if staff forget the PIN?

Go back to **Part A, step 3** and set a new one. There's no way to recover the old one — only replace it.

Do we need Part B if we already set a PIN?

Yes. The PIN alone stops a casual customer poking at a visible exit button; it does nothing about Esc or F11. Part B is what makes those keys harmless.

Quick Reference

ENTER / EXIT LOCKDOWN

`Ctrl` + `Shift` + `L`, then the PIN

WHO CAN SET THE PIN

Tenant Administrator, Branch Manager

SET OR CHANGE THE PIN

Terminals → key icon → Fullscreen Lockdown
PIN

REAL LOCKDOWN (ADDRESS BAR GONE)

Launch browser with `--kiosk` + a fresh `--user-data-dir`

